4

Sidelining Populist Leaders

SWIFT AND coordinated action was crucial to managing the rapidly spreading virus after the COVID-19 outbreak. The WHO was at the center of the global response, tasked with an ambitious mandate: identifying and containing outbreaks, distributing personal protective equipment, and spearheading efforts to develop effective vaccines and treatments.

To fulfill this mission and save lives, the WHO relied heavily on timely, accurate information from member states and other stakeholders, including pharmaceutical companies, medical NGOs, and peer IOs. Granular data on case counts and death rates informed travel advisories, insights on treatment efficacy shaped government policies, and accurate inventories of medical supplies ensured equitable distribution of critical resources.

However, the WHO faced significant resistance from some leaders, many of them populists. Leaders like Donald Trump in the United States and Jair Bolsonaro in Brazil withheld crucial information, failed to standardize reporting at local levels, and even used public platforms to disparage the WHO, blaming it for the pandemic's rapid spread. These actions exacerbated the challenges of responding to the crisis, further complicating the organization's already formidable task (Worsnop 2019).

Despite this noncooperation, the WHO adapted and innovated. Its operational bureaucrats, leaders, and cooperative member states identified creative solutions to fill the information gaps. They leaned on reliable data from countries with robust reporting systems, sought input from third-party sources, and enhanced the WHO's own surveillance capabilities. These